

earn more. Becoming a skilled blue-collar worker is one option. Jobs like boilermakers, construction and building inspectors, electric power line installers, and elevator installation and repair all offer median salaries greater than \$50,000, and they have double-digit projected job growth. Other options for high-paying jobs without a degree include careers in public service, such as law enforcement and firefighting, real estate (agent, property manager) or sales. Many times, success in these careers will require an alternative to a traditional degree, such as getting a certification or working your way up from lower-level jobs with on-the-job training.

Alternatives to traditional four-year colleges have popped up, too. Examples include online computer coding programs that build on the idea that we need to learn a set of stackable skills. In addition to saving money spent on a traditional degree, these programs offer the advantage of being able to change and adapt quickly. In a field like computer science that is rapidly evolving, skills learned at the beginning of a program may become outdated in the four years it takes to complete a traditional degree. You may also change your mind in that time.

Chad Carson shared an excellent example of what is possible if you choose a path that doesn't require extensive formal education.